

Chapter 69-2

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Hospital.

Zhao Xuning walked out of the ward, and Liang Shi immediately stepped forward, asking nervously: "Is she alright?"

"Nothing serious." Zhao Xuning removed her stethoscope. "She fainted due to excessive nervousness. She'll be fine after some rest."

The weight that had been hanging in Liang Shi's heart finally settled.

"So, what happened?" Zhao Xuning asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "Sorry, it involves privacy, so I won't say."

Zhao Xuning didn't continue asking, but went downstairs with her to have a cup of coffee together.

The rain in the city had stopped long ago, and pedestrians on the road remained hurried.

This city was still in the midst of its busyness.

Liang Shi had been caught in the rain, and her clothes were somewhat wet, so she simply took off her coat and draped it over her arm.

The wind was strong, and when it blew on her body, the damp clothes stuck to her, making her particularly uncomfortable.

But Liang Shi was preoccupied and didn't go buy new clothes.

It was only after returning to the hospital that Zhao Xuning gave her one of her own coats to change into.

Zhao Xuning had a shift change after three o'clock. After the handover ended, she came over to check again, instructing Liang Shi to take good care of Xu Qingzhu. She told her to remember to call her back when Xu Qingzhu woke up, then left the hospital.

After that, Liang Shi stayed in the ward the entire time, all the way until evening.

After the heavy rain, the sky produced a brilliant red sunset glow that dyed the distant dark horizon red. Even the color reflected on the glass was rendered in red.

It looked like tomorrow should be good weather.

Liang Shi dozed off in the quiet ward.

Perhaps it was because the emotions during the day were too oppressive—in a trance, she actually dreamed of the abandoned factory.

In the abandoned factory, dark as if there were no sun or sky, smoke swirled around. A group of people spoke in dialects she couldn't understand, and there were two spirited, large yellow dogs¹.

This place seemed to be holding many children, but she couldn't see very clearly.

She lay on the cold cement floor, as if she could die at any moment.

Someone called out to her in a low voice: "Elder sister—"

Then that scene was as if someone had splashed blood on it—countless red marks shattered the image.

That originally cautious voice became filled with a sense of brokenness, as if it were a desperate cry—

"Bang."

Pain came from her forehead, the feeling of weightlessness disappeared, but Liang Shi only opened her eyes slightly, then exhaled.

This dream had no beginning or end, but it was frightening.

She didn't know who was calling her for help.

Or perhaps it was simply stress.

Liang Shi adjusted her breathing several times, reaching up to rub her forehead. After a while, she slowly opened her eyes.

She hardly needed to adjust—outside was already completely dark. Except for the weak light from the street lamps shining in, there was no other light source in the entire ward.

The disinfectant smell unique to hospital rooms made Liang Shi a bit uncomfortable. She rubbed her nose, then used the weak light to go to the door to turn on the lights.

In an instant, light fell into the room, and she looked toward Xu Qingzhu lying on the hospital bed.

The other person squinted her eyes.

Xu Qingzhu let out a light breath, then raised the back of her hand to shield her eyes. Her cool voice carried a bit of hoarseness: "How long did I sleep?"

"Half a day." Liang Shi answered, then asked: "Are you hungry?"

Xu Qingzhu sat up and looked at the needle mark on the back of her hand. After being pricked with a needle, the fair back of her hand always left behind bruises. She frowned slightly, only asking in a low voice: "Can I be discharged?"

"Sure, Zhao Xuning said you simply didn't sleep enough." Liang Shi told a white lie, keeping quiet about the morning incident at the cemetery, and even teased: "Teacher Xu, no matter how busy you are with work, you still need to take care of your health? Staying up late on your day off—do you not value your life?"

Xu Qingzhu tilted her head back slightly. From Liang Shi's angle, she could just see her slender swan neck²—her milky white skin made her entire person seem to glow.

In Liang Shi's mind, countless thoughts had already flashed by: Too thin! Take her to eat something delicious!

At this moment, she looked cold and distant, with a somewhat fragile quality.

Liang Shi also controlled the degree of her joking extremely well, her tone very light, her intonation rising slightly, wanting to bring her a bit of liveliness.

Clearly, after she finished speaking, Xu Qingzhu was slightly stunned, thinking that Liang Shi would ask her about the morning's events.

But Liang Shi didn't mention it at all, only joking with her as usual.

The corners of Xu Qingzhu's lips curved up, bringing up a faint arc. Her clear eyes also curved slightly, her eyes seemingly filled with starlight.

She turned to the side to look toward Liang Shi, meeting Liang Shi's gaze, responding with the same teasing tone as in Liang Shi's words: "No choice, I have to work to support the family."

Liang Shi raised an eyebrow: "So Teacher Xu means I can't provide for us?"

"Well, two people's strength is always greater than one person's, right?" Xu Qingzhu's long hair was scattered over her shoulders. On her delicate collarbone, she wore a silver necklace. Her face still had the pallor from not recovering after excessive emotional tension, her lips without much color. But those eyes, when they hooked upward, just happened to grasp the perfect degree of charm.

Cold and beautiful, yet not lacking in allure.

Her long and upturned eyelashes added a touch of cuteness to her eyes, but her entire face was cold.

Yet the moment the corners of her mouth curved up, it could make all things in the world pale in comparison.

Liang Shi was momentarily stunned.

Footnotes:

¹ Large yellow dogs (大黄狗) - A common breed of dog in China, typically tan/yellow in color, often used as guard dogs in rural areas.

² Swan neck - A Chinese expression used to describe an elegant, slender neck, considered a mark of beauty and grace.